

GLOSSARY

Adze An axe-like weapon on which the blade is at a right angle to the shaft.

Afterburner A component in a jet engine that burns additional fuel with the exhaust gases to increase thrust.

Aileron A hinged surface on an aircraft's wing that controls the aircraft's horizontal orientation.

Armet A helmet developed in 15th-century Europe.

Arquebus A *muzzle-loading* firearm used between the 15th and 17th centuries, which was a forerunner of the 18th-century *musket*.

Arrestor wire A cable used on aircraft carriers to decelerate an aircraft as it lands on deck.

Assault rifle A *magazine-fed* automatic *rifle* that uses an *intermediate cartridge*.

Automatic weapon A firearm that will load and fire continually when the trigger is pressed.

Auxiliaries Additional troops that support the main body of an army; troop support of any kind.

Aventail A curtain of mail that covers the neck and shoulders.

Ballista A Roman missile weapon designed for siege warfare.

Barb A spar on an arrowhead that makes it difficult to remove the arrow once it is embedded.

Barbette An armoured structure protecting a cannon or artillery piece.

Barbuta A visorless steel helmet, which was a form of *sallet*, first produced in the 15th century.

Bardiche An Eastern European staff weapon with a long, cleaver-type blade.

Barding Armour for horses.

Baselard A late-medieval short sword.

Basinet A medieval helmet worn with a visor.

Battalion A military unit of between 300 and 1,200 soldiers.

Battery A group of artillery weapons – usually four to eight.

Battlecruiser A class of heavily armed ship developed as a type of fast *battleship* in the years before World War I.

Battleship The largest type of armed ship in a fleet.

Bayonet A blade designed to fit into, over, under, or around the *muzzle* end of a firearm, enabling it to be used as a close-combat weapon.

Besagew A round plate of armour used to protect the armpit. Also known as a *rondel*.

Blunderbuss A *muzzle-loading* firearm with a short, flared *muzzle*.

Bolt action (rifle) A firearm with a manually operated bolt that, in one action, extracts a spent *cartridge* case and chambers a fresh one.

Bore The internal diameter of a gun barrel – traditionally the number of rounds it was able to take that could be cast from 454g (1lb) of lead.

Bow The front of a ship or a boat.

Breech The rear part of the *bore* of a firearm or artillery piece.

Brigade Three infantry or tank *battalions*.

Brigandine A type of medieval body armour made of small metal plates riveted to a textile covering.

Broadside The simultaneous discharge of some or all of the guns on one side of a warship.

Bullpup A type of *rifle* with a firing mechanism set back in the shoulder *stock*, allowing for a normal-length barrel in a relatively short weapon.

Burgonet An open-faced helmet used widely in the 16th century.

Butt The part of a *rifle* held to the shoulder; the part of a pistol held in the hand.

Calibre The internal diameter of a weapon's barrel; also used to describe specific cartridge types.

Capital ship The most powerful class of warship in a navy.

Carbine A short-barrelled *rifle* or *musket*, typically of a smaller *calibre* than the *rifle*, first designed for cavalry.

Carrack A three- or four-masted sailing ship developed in Europe in the 15th century.

Carronade A short-barrelled, short-range cannon developed by Carron Ironworks, Scotland, c.1770.

Cartridge The package that contains the projectile and propellant used by a firearm.

Casemate A fortified structure designed as a shelter for troops; an artillery enclosure on a warship.

Catapult (aircraft carrier) A track-and-piston system used to launch aircraft from the deck of an aircraft carrier.

Chaff Pieces of metal or plastic released into the air – usually by aircraft – to disrupt enemy radar.

Chain gun A *machine-gun* that loads and fires *cartridges* via an externally powered chain, rather than recoil.

Chamber The part of a firearm from which the *cartridge* is fired.

Chape See *scabbard*.

Chasseur A French light infantry, or light cavalry, soldier trained for rapid action.

Coaxial gun A secondary tank armament, used alongside the primary long gun.

Composite bow A bow made of multiple layers, combining wood with bone, horn, or sinew.

Corbel An arched stone structure supporting the higher parts of a castle's walls.

Corps A military group of two to three divisions.

Corvette A small, lightly armed ship.

Couter A plate or piece of articulated armour that protects the elbow.

Crenel An open space or notch in a battlement or wall.

Crinet Armour that protects a horse's neck.

Crossbow A mechanical bow that shoots wooden or metal bolts.

Crossguard See *quillons*.

Cuirassier A cavalryman named after the metal breast- and back-plate (or "cuirass") that he wore.

Cuisse Medieval armour that protected the thigh.

Dao A Chinese weapon with a single edge, used for slashing.

Destroyer A fast, lightly armoured vessel armed with guns and anti-submarine weapons.

Dirk A dagger traditionally used by naval officers.

Discharger cup A cup fixed to the end of a *rifle* to accept grenades or missiles for firing.

Dragoon A military unit trained to fight on horseback or on foot.

Dreadnought A turbine-powered *battleship* class naval craft armed with heavy guns of uniform *calibre*.

Drone A remotely piloted aircraft typically used for reconnaissance.

Electronic countermeasure An electronic device designed to disrupt enemy radar or sonar.

Elevator A hinged surface on an aircraft's wing that controls the aircraft's vertical orientation.

Elevon A control surface on an aircraft's wing that combines the functions of an *aileron* and an *elevator*.

Elliptical wing An aircraft wing design that minimizes drag.

Enfilade Gunfire directed at an enemy's flank.

Escort carrier A merchant ship converted during World War II to carry aircraft. It carried 6–35 aircraft, far fewer than the larger *fleet carrier*.

Extractor The moving part of a firearm that removes spent casings from the *chamber* after firing.

Falconet A type of light medieval cannon.

Fauld A skirt of armour that protects the waist and hips.

Field gun Artillery designed to be portable rather than fixed.

Firestep A step built or cut into the wall of a trench to allow soldiers to fire over the edge.

Firing pin The part of a firing mechanism used in certain firearms and explosive devices to detonate the charge.

First-rate ship The designation used by the British Royal Navy for the largest ships of the line, its smaller vessels being classed as second- or third-rate.

Flanchards Armour to protect a horse's flanks.

Flash suppressor/hider A device that reduces the flash caused by gasses burnt on firing a gun.

Fleet carrier An aircraft carrier intended to operate with the main fleet of a navy.

Flintlock A firing mechanism in which a flint strikes a steel surface, creating sparks that ignite the charge.

Frigate An 18th- or 19th-century warship with two full decks; a 20th-century warship with anti-submarine capability.

Fuller A groove cut into a blade to make it lighter.

Fulminate A type of explosive that is sensitive to shock.

Fuselage The main body of an aircraft.

Galleon A square-rigged, three-masted sailing ship in use between the 16th and 18th centuries.

Gauntlets Armoured gloves.

Gimbal A device that keeps a ship's compasses horizontal despite the ship's movements.

Glaive A European staff weapon consisting of a single-edged blade attached to the end of a pole.

Gorget An armoured collar designed to protect the throat.

GPMG General-purpose *machine-gun*.

Greave Armour that protects the leg from knee to ankle.

Gunport A square hole cut into the side of a sailing warship through which guns are fired.

Half-track A vehicle with wheels at the front and tank-style caterpillar tracks at the back.

Hanger A sword with a short, wide blade, often used at sea.

Hauberk A thigh-length mail coat or shirt.

Head-up display A transparent data screen that can be viewed looking forwards out of an aircraft.

Heavy cruiser A class of warship that is smaller than a *battleship*; its main armament is usually 8in guns.

Heavy machine-gun A *machine-gun* chambered for a round of larger-than-*rifle calibre*, usually 12.7mm; a *machine-gun* fired from a fixed mount.

Hilt The hand-held part of a word, including the grip, guard, and *pommel*.

Horsepower A unit of power equal to the energy required to raise 250kg (550lb) 30cm (1ft) in one second.

Howitzer A high-angle artillery piece used for destroying fortifications and trench systems.

Hydro-pneumatic recoil A recoil system with a gas-charged shock absorber, used in modern, quick-firing mounted guns.

Iklwa A flat-bladed Zulu stabbing spear, also known as an assegai.

Incendiary shell/round A projectile designed to start a fire.

Inertial navigation A high-tech navigation system that uses dead-reckoning to calculate the position of a moving object without requiring external references.